

THEIR CRAFT, THEIR PROFIT
Industree Foundation CEO Neju George Abraham with women producers/ shareholders of Greenkraft at an MBT unit near Bengaluru

by Dhanabhagyam and her colleagues. Weaving that beauty is what saved them from grinding farm labour. Now these products will be used to train 300 women at nine such units under the MBT. Thus, things created in the beating heart of rural India find their way to the living rooms of gleaming metropolises. Among Greenkraft's global customers are the Japanese brand Muji, French retailer Carrefour and home decor brand Caravane.

"Though we look rural, our processes are world-class in terms of quality assurance. Otherwise, global buyers will never buy from us," says Neju George Abraham, CEO of the Bengaluru-based Industree Foundation.

Greenkraft started with women's collectives producing banana fibre products in Tamil Nadu and sal leaf plates in Odisha, before turning its focus to bamboo in 2021. As Neju explains, bamboo is a versatile natural fibre that can straddle an entire value chain—with sufficient R&D, it can be a replacement for the timber used for paper, viscose rayon, plywoods and boards. Ironically, India is among the largest importers of raw bamboo. Hence, Industree is also on a mission to create a million 'lakhpathi didis' by promoting bamboo cultivation—there are 30,200 women in the bamboo value chain—and providing livelihood for women artisans, through ventures like Greenkraft, near their homes. Such as the hamlets near MM Hills, one of Karnataka's most backward regions.

Dhanabhagyam earns Rs 10,000-13,000 a month and supports her ailing husband. Such gritty stories of survival are common amongst Greenkraft artisans in Martahalli and further up the hills, like in the tribal hamlet of Ponnachi, where women slice raw bamboo into wafer-thin slivers for weaving. Besides the Greenkraft label that binds the sorority, there's another band of unity—the pride they take in their work with every fibre of their being. ■

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